

Waders, gulls, and auks

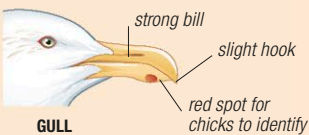
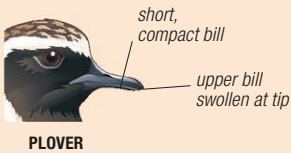
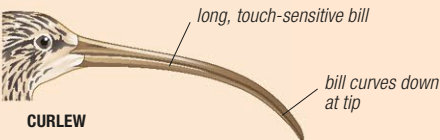
PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Charadriiformes
FAMILIES	19
SPECIES	384

In many parts of the world, these birds are a common sight at sea, along shorelines, and in wetlands. Most are strong fliers that feed on other animals in or near water. Waders or shorebirds (which include sandpipers, plovers, avocets, stilts, snipes, curlews, and jacanas) are long-legged birds that feed by

the water's edge. Gulls (which embrace terns, skuas, and skimmers) use their flying skills to catch prey. Auks (including puffins and murres) dive underwater for food. Auks look strikingly similar to penguins but are able to fly and are confined to the Northern Hemisphere. Waders and gulls occur worldwide, but many species are threatened by habitat destruction, oil pollution, or hunting.

Anatomy

Most of the birds in this group have subdued black, white, brown, or gray plumage, but some have colorful bare parts, such as the bill, eyes, legs, and mouth linings. Many go through radical plumage changes, both between seasons and in maturing to adulthood. The 3 groups exhibit major differences, especially in the legs, which are long in the waders but short and web-footed in the rotund, upright auks. Most birds in the group have salt glands above the eyes that enable them to extract the fluids they require from seawater and expel the excess salts through the nostrils.



BILL SHAPES
These birds exhibit a wide variety of bill shapes, each adapted for a different feeding method—the curlew has a long, downcurved, touch-sensitive bill that is ideal for probing deep into mud, while plovers have a short, pigeonlike bill used for picking up food that is detected by sight, not touch. Gulls have a robust, multipurpose bill that is slightly hooked for tearing food.

NESTING TERNS
Most terns (including these elegant terns) breed in colonies, seeking an isolated place such as an island or reef for protection. The colonies are usually found on flat, open ground and are often densely populated.

CATCHING FISH



FINDING PREY
A western gull detects a fish beneath the surface of the water and swoops down toward it.

CAPTURE
With rapid wingbeats, the gull plunges its stout bill into the water and plucks out the fish.

TAKING OFF
Having successfully captured its prey, the gull takes off with the fish in its bill.

STEADY FLIGHT
The gull flies low over the water, heading toward a suitable feeding site.